CitiLink-News

Annotation Manual

Version 1.0

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Purificação Silvano[1,4]
Sara Nerea[3]
Raquel Sequeira[3]
Inês Cantante[1,4]
Rute Rebouças[1,4]
Ricardo Campos[3,4]

[1] University of Porto, Porto, Portugal
[2] University of Macau, Macau
[3] University of Beira Interior, Covilhã, Portugal
[4] INESC TEC, Porto, Portugal

Introduction

This manual was developed as part of the *CitiLink – Enhancing Municipal Transparency and Citizen Engagement through AI: From Unstructured to Structured Data* project (https://citilink.inesctec.pt/), which aims to facilitate access to and understanding of municipal council meeting minutes by structuring information about the items discussed and the decisions recorded.

CitiLink-News extends this work by focusing on assessing the news potential of discussion items and producing news articles from the corresponding segments.

The manual provides guidelines for the human annotation of seven news values, each rated on a scale from 1 to 5, and for a binary newsworthiness decision. The definition of newsworthiness criteria draws, among others, on Galtung and Ruge (1965), Wolf (1987), Traquina (2002), Harcup and O'Neill (2001, 2017), Caple (2018), and Público's style guide (Público, 1998).

These guidelines aim to promote the consistent application of the criteria while acknowledging the interpretive nature of newsworthiness assessment.

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A. Unit of Analysis and General Procedure

A.1. Discussion Item

Definition. A segment of meeting minutes describing an item discussed or decided upon at a municipal council meeting. The unit of analysis in CitiLink-News is the segment previously identified in the CitiLink-Minutes annotation, rather than the complete set of minutes.

Scope. The start and end boundaries of each discussion item, previously marked in the CitiLink discussion-item layer (Discussion Item – Start Boundary; Discussion Item – End Boundary), are used. This manual does not redefine the segmentation of the minutes.

Segment example. "The Municipal Council resolved to approve the traffic management plan for the Northern Access Road – Teixoso." (Example adapted from the CitiLink annotation guidelines.)

A.2. General Procedure

1. Read the entire segment corresponding to the discussion item.
2. Identify the explicitly stated information needed to assess each of the seven news values; assign a score from 1 to 5 to each dimension according to the defined scale.
3. Assign the binary newsworthiness classification (0 or 1) separately. Do not derive this decision by adding up the news-value scores.
4. Flag any cases that are difficult to interpret for discussion and alignment of criteria among team members.
5. Keep each annotation linked to the segment identifier and the source meeting minutes.

B. News Values – Definitions and Regional Rating Scale

Each of the seven news values is annotated separately on an ordinal scale from 1 to 5, with higher scores indicating a stronger presence of the property being assessed.

B.1. Relevance

Definition. The importance of an item in terms of its consequences for people's lives or the community. Relevance may be social, political, economic, cultural, or of another kind. It does not depend solely on the number of people involved.

Illustrative example. The closure of a local health care facility or a medical specialty service. Score – 5

Score	Criterion — Relevance
1	Impact on one individual or a very small group of people.
2	Impact on a neighborhood or a specific civil parish.
3	Impact on a village, town, city, or major local sector (economic, political, social, cultural, among others).
4	Impact on the entire municipality or an administrative region.
5	Structural impact that changes the future of the region, or a threat to the lives of local residents.

B.2. Proximity

Definition. The degree of geographic or cultural proximity between an event and the local community the information is intended to reach.

Illustrative example. A robbery in a municipality in the Covilhã region would receive a higher score for an audience in Covilhã than a robbery in a municipality in the Lisbon area.

Score	Criterion — Proximity
1	Event outside the district or region, with no local connection.
2	Event in a neighboring municipality with some cultural affinity.
3	Event in another civil parish within the same municipality.
4	Event within the municipality.
5	Event in the immediate local community (e.g., on the street, in the main square, or at the school).

B.3. Novelty

Definition. The new, unexpected, or distinctive nature of an event, including new information about previously known issues.

Illustrative example. An international event being held in the region for the first time. Score – 5

Score	Criterion — Novelty
1	Recurring event.
2	Expected event with a minor variation.
3	Change of direction in a local project.
4	Disclosure of new information or a different perspective on a longstanding problem or local project.
5	New event or new project.

B.4. Timeliness

Definition. The temporal proximity of an event to the reference time used for assessment. More recent or ongoing events receive higher scores.

Illustrative example. An active wildfire in the region's mountains. Score – 5

Score	Criterion — Timeliness
1	Event that occurred more than two weeks ago.
2	Event that occurred a few days ago.
3	Event that occurred the previous day.
4	Event that occurred today.
5	Event currently in progress.

Note. Applying the scale requires identifying the relevant temporal reference point. The source segment may not explicitly establish that reference point in every case.

B.5. Continuity

Definition. The relationship of an item to a story or event that is, or could be, the subject of ongoing news coverage, including follow-up developments and anniversaries.

Illustrative example. Following a well-known case over several days or reporting on the later consequences of a past event.
Score – 5

Score	Criterion — Continuity
1	Isolated event unlikely to receive follow-up coverage.
2	Minor development in an event.
3	Moderate ongoing coverage of a local issue.
4	Commemoration of a local anniversary or a new chapter in a political conflict within the municipality.
5	Case that sustains, or could sustain, a major regional news story over several days, weeks, or months.

B.6. Prominence
Definition. The degree of public recognition or institutional importance of the people and organizations involved in the item.

Illustrative example. The mayor announces the municipality's budget for the following year.
Score – 5

Score	Criterion — Prominence
1	Unknown individual or local resident.
2	Well-known local figure.
3	Person of national or international distinction visiting the locality.
4	Person holding an important local institutional position (e.g., parish council president, municipal councilor, or local school principal).
5	Highest-ranking regional authority or public figure with regional influence (e.g., the mayor, the diocesan bishop, or a member of parliament elected from the constituency).

Note. The examples cover categories of different kinds (public prestige and institutional position); where these overlap, the criterion applied should be recorded and discussed.

B.7. Negativity
Definition. The severity of negative consequences or characteristics associated with an event, particularly losses, conflicts, or risky situations.

Illustrative example. The closure of the municipality's largest factory, leaving hundreds of workers unemployed. Score – 5

Score	Criterion — Negativity
1	Positive or neutral news story with no significant negative element.
2	Event with minor negative consequences.
3	Event with some negative consequences for the local community.
4	Event with negative consequences for part of the community.
5	Event with very negative consequences for the entire local community.

C. Binary Newsworthiness Classification

C.1. Definition and Possible Values

Definition. An overall assessment of a meeting-minutes segment's potential to become a news article of local interest. The classification distinguishes potentially newsworthy items from those whose content does not, under the adopted criteria, warrant a news story.

Value	Category	Interpretation
0	Not newsworthy	In the overall assessment, the item is not considered sufficiently newsworthy.
1	Newsworthy	The item has the potential to be developed into a news article.

C.2. Application Criteria

- The annotator assigns the classification after reading the segment and making an overall assessment of its journalistic potential in the local context.
- The binary classification is independent of the seven ordinal scores. These may inform the assessment but do not replace human judgment.
- A particularly strong journalistic dimension may contribute to the overall decision, even if not all dimensions receive high scores.
- If the segment does not provide enough information to clarify a decisive aspect, the case should be flagged for discussion rather than introducing undocumented facts.

Examples for illustration only. The closure of a health care service with a significant impact on residents may be newsworthy; a routine administrative update with no explicitly stated significant consequences may not be.

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